



The AI Operations Maturity Model

A framework for understanding where AI actually stands in your operations — not which tools you've bought, but how decisions, ownership and execution actually work.

Most organizations measure AI maturity by counting tools: which platforms are licensed, which pilots are live, which team has a chatbot. That's a poor proxy. The organizations that get real value from AI aren't the ones with the most tools — they're the ones where AI is tied to a clear owner, a measurable outcome and a repeatable workflow.

We assess maturity across four stages. Most organizations sit lower than they expect — not because the technology is missing, but because the operating structure around it hasn't caught up.

1. Fragmented

the default starting point

AI shows up in pockets. Individual teams or people have adopted tools on their own, with no shared standard, no accountable owner, and no link back to a business outcome.

- Different teams use different tools for similar tasks, with no one coordinating
- No one could tell you who is accountable if an AI-assisted decision goes wrong
- Leadership hears about AI use anecdotally, not through any reporting line

2. Emerging

structure starts to form

Some functions have a defined approach, but it hasn't spread across the organization. Systems and data are still fragmented enough that scaling what works is genuinely hard.

- One or two functions have a real workflow; the rest are still improvising
- Underlying data lives in disconnected systems, so nothing scales cleanly
- Wins exist but stay local — they don't transfer to other teams

3. Aligned

consistent, but not everywhere

AI use is consistently applied within functions and clearly tied to a business metric — revenue, cost, retention or margin. It just isn't cross-functional yet, and governance is still informal.

- Each function can point to a metric AI use is actually moving
- Adoption is consistent within teams, but coordination across teams is ad hoc
- Basic guardrails exist, but there's no enterprise-wide review process

4. Optimized

the operating standard

AI is embedded enterprise-wide, with named ownership, real governance, and a direct, visible line to business performance that changes what leaders decide.

- Leaders get signal that changes decisions — not just more dashboards
- Defined risk controls and review processes cover AI use org-wide
- The org can absorb a new AI use case without re-litigating ownership each time

What actually determines your stage

Operational Alignment

Ownership & Accountability

Data & Systems Integration

Revenue & Efficiency Linkage

Leadership Visibility & Decision-Making

Governance & Risk Controls

Want your organization's actual stage — not just the one that sounds right?

The full AI Operations Maturity Scorecard scores all six dimensions individually and gives you a specific, defensible stage classification with a recommended next step. We walk it live in a Strategy Call.

[Book a Strategy Call → ilene.ai/contact.html](#)